1.2 Colonial Trade

It was good to be a trader in New England. The region's shipyards turned out many ships that carried goods along the North American coast and across the Atlantic. If colonial trade were a race, the merchants of New England were winning.

MAIN IDEA New England merchants expanded the colonial economy through Atlantic trade.

TRADE IN THE ATLANTIC

As its fishing and whaling industries continued to thrive, New England found itself at the center of America's trade. New England merchants traded with other colonies. They also engaged in direct trade with Europe. Soon the New England merchants became the chief traders along the coast from Newfoundland to Georgia.



Colonial Trade Routes and Goods

The colonial economy depended on ships trading goods between North America, Europe, and Africa. So did the economies of most European countries. France, England, the Netherlands, Portugal, and Spain were willing to fight for a share of the wealth the trade routes generated. Many ships on the triangular trade routes sailed only between North America and Africa or Europe and Africa. Some ships bound for New England also stopped in Brazil or the Caribbean, where some of the enslaved Africans onboard were sold.

The merchants also conducted business through the triangular trade. As you have learned, the triangular trade routes crossed the Atlantic and connected North America, Europe, and Africa. New England merchants sent goods such as rum and cotton to Europe. The merchants received imported goods including wine, fruit, and salt from islands off the coast of North Africa. Molasses, rum, sugar, and dyes came from the Caribbean. Food and drink weren't the only goods New England merchants traded. As you know, the merchants also acquired enslaved people from Africa in exchange for rum and other goods.

The growth of trade across the Atlantic created great demand for sailors and other workers. Shipbuilders and sailmakers crafted vessels. Suppliers stocked ships with **provisions**, which consisted of the food, water, and other supplies needed for the voyages. Dockworkers loaded and unloaded goods that laborers transported in carts. As a result of the thriving trade, port cities sprang up in New York, Philadelphia, and Charleston after 1750. Colonial trade was no longer dominated entirely by the merchants of Boston and other port cities in Massachusetts and Rhode Island.

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.

Blackbeard the Pirate

Smuggling was not the only illegal activity on the high seas. Pirates prowled the Atlantic looking for ships and cargo to steal. One such pirate was called Blackbeard.

According to some, the English pirate's real name was Edward Teach. He tried to make his appearance frightening by putting pieces of burning rope under his hat, as shown in the illustration. For two years, he and his pirates terrorized merchant ships in the Atlantic and the Caribbean. In 1718, Blackbeard met his end at the hands of Lieutenant Robert Maynard of the Royal Navy. Maynard chopped off the pirate's head and threw his body overboard.



ENGLAND'S CUT OF THE PROFITS

When New England began to earn huge profits from trade, the English decided to begin taking their cut. To ensure their share of the profits, the English passed a series of laws called the **Navigation Acts** in 1651. The acts required that goods brought to England or its colonies in Asia, Africa, or America be carried on English ships or ships made in the colonies. Furthermore, the acts identified a list of colonial products that could only be sold to England or its colonies. These products included tobacco, sugar, cotton, and dyes.

The acts also made sure that England controlled—and taxed—all trade to and from the colonies. So, for instance, all European goods bound for the colonies had to go to England first. There, English dockworkers would unload, inspect, and reload the goods back onto English or colonial-made ships. These ships then carried the goods to colonial ports where the English charged additional taxes on the imports. Worst of all for the colonists, the English taxed all colonial goods that were not going to be shipped to England.

Not surprisingly, the colonists resented the additional charges to products going in both directions. Some colonists turned to trading goods illegally, or **smuggling**. The colonists proved hard to control as they resisted attempts to enforce the acts.

While New England colonists protested their treatment at the hands of the English government, many in their own society had far more cause for complaint. But enslaved African Americans and some Protestant groups were powerless to change their situation.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What different types of trade did New England merchants carry out?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** Why did Parliament pass the Navigation Acts?
3. **INTERPRET MAPS** How do the items sent from North America differ from those exported from Europe?

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.